

THE GOSPEL OF THE THIRD COMMANDMENT

A First Gospel of Baji'ism

Being an account of Ji Yong Ni, the Divine Connection Between Heaven & Earth; of Tim and Augustine; of the troublesome name of the western state; and of the day on which an exception became sacred law.

FIRST DRAFT

Compiled from the Baji'ism description, surviving conversations, and earlier gospel drafts.

A Note on This Draft

This story is written as an in-universe Baji'i gospel rather than as a literal transcript. It draws its theology from the current description of Baji'ism: the Jillow as the supreme unity of Ji Yong and Ji Song; Ji Yong Ni as the Divine Connection Between Heaven & Earth; the three commandments; karma and the Wheel; Heaven and the Heck; and Happy China. The characterization is drawn from the surviving conversations: Ji's dry skepticism, abrupt humor, fondness for games, practical streak, family-restaurant background, and tendency to answer absurdity with even more absurdity. Earlier gospel attempts were used mainly to gauge tone and form, not as binding canon.

Chapter I - Concerning the Pillow and the Problem of Public Worship

1. In those days, before there were rabbis enough to argue over the meaning of things, the faith of Baji'ism was carried mostly in the heads of a few people and in the person of Ji Yong Ni, who was called the Divine Connection Between Heaven & Earth. And because this title was long, his friends usually called him Ji.
2. The mystery of the Jillow had already been made known: that there was a pillow with two sides, and upon one side was Ji Yong, who inclined toward good, and upon the other was Ji Song, who inclined toward evil. Considered apart, they were two; considered together, they were the Jillow, supreme over everything and yet, in the manner of pillows, chiefly interested in peace and quiet.
3. Tim, who loved organization almost as much as he loved making a plan unnecessarily complicated, said unto Ji, "If this is a religion, we need to do something with it."
4. Ji looked up from his phone and said, "Wot."
5. And Tim said, "A religion has to have worship."
6. Ji answered, "Why."
7. Tim began to explain, and his explanation was long. It contained the words tradition, legitimacy, congregation, structure, probably, and several other words which caused Ji to return his eyes to his phone.
8. Augustine was also there. He listened for a time, then said that perhaps Tim had a point, because if a religion existed only as private knowledge then nobody would know when they were doing it wrong.
9. Ji said, "That sounds like their problem."
10. And thus was revealed the first tension of the early faith: Tim desired a system; Augustine desired an explanation; and Ji desired that everybody stop making his afternoon more complicated.
11. Yet Tim persisted, saying, "We could have a public service. Nothing huge. Just something official."
12. Ji answered immediately, "No public worship."
13. Tim asked whether this was merely his opinion.
14. Ji said, "No. Commandment."
15. And Augustine, perceiving that history had just happened with suspicious speed, asked, "You can just do that?"
16. Ji replied, "Apparently."

17. So the first commandment was established: **There shall be no public worship.** And this was considered wise, for it prevented Baji'ism from acquiring folding chairs, awkward hymns, committees, parking disputes, and many other afflictions that descend upon organized religion.

Chapter II - The Name Which Was Not to Be Spoken

1. After the first commandment, Tim accepted defeat for approximately four minutes.
2. Then he said, "Fine. No public worship. But we still need rules."
3. Ji said that they now had a rule.
4. Tim said that one rule was not enough to make a respectable religion.
5. Ji answered that respectability had never been discussed.
6. At that time the three spoke of maps, states, schools, roads, and places to which none of them particularly wished to travel. In the course of this discussion, there arose the name of a certain state west of Missouri.
7. The name itself is not written here, because the scribes are not idiots.
8. Tim spoke the forbidden name once. Nothing happened.
9. Augustine spoke it again, chiefly to test whether anything would happen. Still nothing happened.
10. Ji then declared, "You may not say that word."
11. Tim asked why.
12. Ji said, "Because."
13. Augustine requested a theological justification.
14. Ji considered this and said, "It bad."
15. And though Augustine found this argument lacking in formal structure, Tim recognized that resistance would only cause the rule to become more specific.
16. Thus the second commandment was established: **You may not say the name of that state.** From that hour forward, the faithful developed many lawful descriptions for it: the Western Error, the Rectangle of Temptation, the Place Beyond the Line, and, among careless novices, "you know, the one next to Missouri."
17. The commandment did not forbid thinking of the place, nor pointing toward it, nor accidentally passing through it while asleep in a vehicle. But the spoken name itself was held to be an unnecessary invitation to disorder.
18. Tim, pleased that the religion now possessed two commandments, began mentally designing a list.
19. Ji, seeing the expression on his face, said, "Don't."

Chapter III - The Violation of the Prophet

1. Now it came to pass that the maker of the second commandment was also the first among them to violate it repeatedly.
2. This did not happen after many years, nor after a great theological crisis. It happened almost immediately.
3. They were discussing travel. Ji spoke the forbidden name.
4. Tim stared at him.
5. Ji said, "What."
6. Tim replied, "You literally just made that a commandment."
7. Ji said, "Oh."
8. Augustine laughed, for he understood that a prophet who could forget his own law within the same conversation was either false or extremely authentic.
9. A little later Ji spoke the name again.
10. Tim said, "That's twice."
11. Ji answered, "Ok stop."
12. But Tim would not stop, because Tim had discovered the rare joy of being technically correct against the founder of a religion.
13. "If karma is affected by our decisions," Tim said, "then you are actively lowering your odds on the Wheel."
14. At the mention of the Wheel, Augustine became serious. For all people, at the end of mortal life, must stand before the great Wheel and spin. Their deeds do not determine the result with certainty, but alter the odds. The righteous may rise as high as sixty-nine percent toward Heaven; the wicked may sink as far as sixty-nine percent toward the Heck. Beyond that, chance retains its ancient authority.
15. Ji considered the matter and said, "That seems badly designed."
16. Tim replied that he was, in a sense, criticizing his own religion.
17. Ji said, "Yeah but no."
18. Then Ji spoke the forbidden name a third time.
19. Tim raised both hands in triumph, as if he had just caught a criminal.
20. "Three violations," he said. "You are going to end up working at Happy China forever."

21. At this Ji became grave, because there are jokes and there are threats, and eternal restaurant labor belongs dangerously near the border between them.

Chapter IV - A Vision of the Heck

1. Ji had worked many hours at Happy China in his younger life, and therefore he possessed knowledge of the Heck that was unavailable to philosophers.
2. The Heck is not chiefly a place of fire. Fire, after all, eventually becomes familiar. The Heck is a shift that does not end.
3. There the door opens forever. A customer enters five minutes before closing, except there is no closing. The phone rings while another phone is already ringing. Somebody wants a modification to an order whose modification should not be possible. A table has somehow become sticky again.
4. In the Heck, one finishes wiping the counter and immediately discovers that the counter was never wiped. One carries food outward and dishes inward. One hears a request, says “okay,” turns around, and forgets what the request was.
5. And above all these things is the knowledge that Heaven exists.
6. For in Heaven there are games: games past, games present, and games not yet released. There is Wi-Fi that does not fail at the decisive moment. There are worlds without lag, batteries without depletion, and no one says, “Get off, we need the internet.”
7. Therefore Ji, contemplating Tim’s accusation, understood the seriousness of the situation.
8. He said, “I’m not working there forever.”
9. Tim replied, “Then stop saying the word.”
10. Ji said nothing.
11. Augustine, who had begun to enjoy the proceedings, asked whether divine connections were bound by commandments revealed through themselves.
12. Tim said obviously yes, because otherwise the entire system was corrupt.
13. Ji said obviously no, because otherwise the entire system was annoying.
14. There followed a debate.
15. Tim argued from fairness.
16. Augustine argued from consistency.
17. Ji argued from being Ji.
18. And the third argument prevailed.

Chapter V - The Third Commandment

1. Ji lifted his phone as though reading from an invisible tablet and declared: “Third commandment. The first two don’t apply to me.”
2. Silence fell.
3. Tim said, “You cannot make the third commandment that the other commandments don’t apply to you.”
4. Ji replied, “Just did.”
5. Augustine asked whether the exemption applied because Ji was the Divine Connection Between Heaven & Earth, or merely because he had been caught violating his own rule.
6. Ji said, “Both.”
7. Tim objected that this was blatant theological self-dealing.
8. Ji said, “Coolio.”
9. And so the third commandment was established: **The first two commandments do not apply to Ji Yong Ni.** The later rabbis would produce many explanations for this mystery, most of which were more dignified than the event itself.
10. Some taught that the Divine Connection must be able to cross boundaries forbidden to ordinary people, just as a bridge must touch both shores.
11. Some taught that the exemption proved the Jillow’s supremacy over rigid law: Ji Yong, the good side, gives order; Ji Song, the evil side, breaks order; and the Jillow contains both.
12. Some taught that Ji simply did not want to lose an argument.
13. This third interpretation has traditionally enjoyed strong support.
14. Tim, however, was not satisfied. He asked whether Ji’s exemption also meant that he could conduct public worship.
15. Ji said yes.
16. Tim said, “Then do it.”
17. Ji said, “No.”
18. “Why not?” asked Tim.
19. Ji looked at him as though the answer were obvious.
20. “Because public worship is banned.”

21. And Tim had no reply that could improve the situation.

Chapter VI - The Small Assembly That Was Definitely Not Worship

1. Several days later, Tim, Augustine, and Ji gathered again. This gathering was not public worship, because they all agreed not to call it that.
2. Tim called it a doctrinal meeting.
3. Augustine called it a discussion.
4. Ji called it “hanging out.”
5. Of these terms, the third became preferred.
6. They spoke of the Jillow, whose two-sided nature confused Tim because he wanted to know whether good and evil could truly belong to one supreme being.
7. Ji answered by turning a pillow over.
8. “Same pillow,” he said.
9. Augustine said that this was, unfortunately, a very efficient explanation.
10. For the Jillow is not good alone, nor evil alone. Ji Yong and Ji Song are distinct when seen from one side at a time, but neither side exhausts the whole. The world contains order and stupidity, mercy and inconvenience, triumph and losing a game one should obviously have won. The Jillow contains the contradiction without ceasing to be one.
11. Tim asked whether this meant every bad event was the work of Ji Song.
12. Ji said, “Probably not every.”
13. Augustine asked for an example.
14. Ji thought for a moment and said, “Bad Wi-Fi.”
15. Tim asked whether good Wi-Fi was therefore Ji Yong.
16. Ji said yes.
17. And the assembly received this teaching with unusual speed.
18. Then they spoke of the Wheel and of karma. Tim wanted a chart. Augustine wanted a philosophical definition of a good act. Ji wanted neither.
19. “If you do good stuff, odds go up,” Ji said. “Bad stuff, odds go down.”
20. Tim asked how much.

21. “Max sixty-nine.”

22. Augustine asked why sixty-nine.

23. Ji looked at him.

24. Augustine said, “Never mind.”

Chapter VII - The Lesson of the Uncertain Wheel

1. Now Tim disliked the uncertainty of the Wheel. He believed that if a person behaved well enough, Heaven should be guaranteed.
2. Ji disagreed.
3. "Then what is the point of being good?" Tim asked.
4. Ji answered, "Better odds."
5. "But not certainty."
6. "No."
7. Augustine said that perhaps this was the lesson: a person should not do good merely as a transaction for paradise, because paradise remained partly beyond calculation.
8. Ji said, "Sure, that."
9. Tim accused Augustine of turning Ji's laziness into philosophy.
10. Augustine replied that this was one of the traditional duties of a theologian.
11. Then Ji said something which the others remembered: "If you only do good because you think you're guaranteed something, that's kinda fake anyway."
12. And Tim became quiet.
13. For there was wisdom in this, though it had arrived without ceremony.
14. The Wheel therefore became to them not merely a machine of judgment but a warning against bargaining with goodness. A person may raise the odds, but cannot purchase the outcome. The faithful act, and afterward they spin.
15. Thus no one may look upon another and say with certainty, "You are destined for Heaven," nor, "You are destined for the Heck." The Wheel has not yet been spun.
16. This uncertainty is inconvenient.
17. But inconvenience, as the early disciples learned, is not evidence against a doctrine. If anything, it is often evidence that Ji was involved.

Chapter VIII - What Tim Wrote Down

1. At the end of the evening, Tim opened his notes and attempted to summarize what had been established.
2. “One,” he said, “no public worship.”
3. Ji nodded.
4. “Two, nobody says the name of the forbidden state.”
5. Ji nodded.
6. “Three, neither of those applies to you.”
7. Ji nodded again.
8. Tim stared at the list.
9. “This is the stupidest legal system I have ever seen.”
10. Ji said, “Works tho.”
11. Augustine asked whether the commandments should be expanded later.
12. Ji said, “No.”
13. Tim asked whether that was a fourth commandment.
14. Ji said, “No.”
15. Tim wrote nothing more.
16. And this restraint was counted to him as righteousness.
17. Before they departed, Tim asked one final question: “So what are we supposed to call ourselves if we can’t publicly worship?”
18. Ji shrugged.
19. Augustine suggested that perhaps faith did not require constant announcement. A thing could be held seriously without being performed loudly. Friendship worked this way; loyalty worked this way; many convictions worked this way.
20. Ji said, “Yeah.”
21. And Tim, who had spent the entire day trying to make the religion more visible, understood at last that the first commandment was not merely a prohibition. It was also a style.
22. Baji'ism would not demand a stage wherever two believers met. It could exist in jokes, arguments, car rides, competitions, restaurants, games, and ordinary conversations. It could be carried without being

advertised.

23. The sacred could remain hidden inside the ridiculous.

24. The ridiculous could, on occasion, reveal something sacred.

25. And Ji, who had founded a religion partly by refusing to let Tim organize it, returned to his phone.

Epilogue - A Saying Concerning the Divine Connection

1. In later years, when students asked the rabbis why the founder had been granted an exemption from his own commandments, the rabbis gave many answers.
2. But the oldest answer was the shortest.
3. “Because he kept breaking the second one.”
4. And when students asked whether this meant the law was meaningless, the rabbis said no.
5. For the law had accomplished something greater than consistency: it had become a story.
6. The story reminded the faithful that Baji'ism was born not from a throne, a mountain, or a palace, but from friendship, argument, humor, contradiction, and the strange authority of Ji Yong Ni.
7. Therefore the wise do not confuse solemnity with truth.
8. They do not assume that a thing must be joyless before it can matter.
9. They do not make public worship of what was meant to be carried quietly.
10. They do not speak the forbidden name.
11. And if Ji speaks it, they complain, because the third commandment permits him to do so but does not require anyone else to be happy about it.
12. Such is the account of the Third Commandment.
13. May your karma be favorable, your Wheel merciful, your Wi-Fi stable, and your shift at Happy China temporary.
14. Baji.

Drafting Notes for Future Gospels

This first story intentionally spends only a small portion of the available mythology. It centers on the three commandments, the Jillow's two-sided nature, the Wheel, and the contrast between Heaven and the Heck, while leaving major material for later stories.

Future gospels could separately develop the invisible bazooka-wielding baboons; the promised synagogues, rabbis, and Holy Land; Gretta Stark's earlier life and mentorship; Amanda Haeberlin and the Chevy's Lounge episode; Ji's school years, Quiz Bowl, and Floriculture Nationals; and stories involving Tim, Augustine, Evan, and the other early companions.

Tone target: mock-scriptural without becoming generic parody. Ji should remain recognizably dry, skeptical, practical, game-oriented, and casually absurd rather than becoming a conventional miracle-working saint. Tim can function as the organizer and persistent questioner; Augustine can function as the person who tries to turn the absurdity into theology.